

Bull RDBMS 1990 and 2024 Metadata

INGRES/SYBASE CUSTOMER SATISFACTION SURVEY

Prepared For: Bull Corporate Strategy & Marketing

By:

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Bull and AberdeenGroup Confidential Page Ingres/Sybase Customer Satisfaction
Survey 28 March 1990

SUMMARY

Objectives:

Aberdeen Group was asked by Bull Corporate Strategy & Marketing to survey users of Ingres and Sybase software for high-performance online transaction processing applications and to determine their satisfaction levels.

Aberdeen's first objective was to identify leading-edge users of both Ingres and Sybase systems. We used various sources (online database searches, both historical and current customer references, and Aberdeen client contacts) to establish a listing of customers we wished to interview.

Aberdeen's second objective was to separate customers' real satisfaction levels about Ingres and Sybase from the marketing puffery that often appears in the trade press. It has been Aberdeen's experience that many customers will overly praise a supplier's products in return for "special" attention and support. The survey guide was designed to establish the contact's position within the enterprise and why and what the contact might report. In addition, Aberdeen is well known in the U.S. for doing in-depth interviews of users for eventual public comment. As a result, many MIS executives feel very comfortable reporting to Aberdeen anonymously what they will not directly tell their supplier or their supplier's competitors.

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Aberdeen's third objective was to compare the responses from Ingres and Sybase users on a normalized basis. At this time, there are no production users who are equally proficient and experienced with both product sets. However, through the acquisition,

development and implementation process users will have different reactions to similar circumstances based upon the capability of their products.

Aberdeen's fourth objective was to analyze the results of this survey in the perspective of trends in the RDBMS field, Aberdeen's historical knowledge of Ingres and Sybase -- including extensive interviews with the management's of both firms, and a recent briefing of Bull's organization and strategy provided to Aberdeen by Bull during the Hanover Fair, 21-22 March 1990.

SUMMARY

Findings:

#1. Even the most advanced users of Ingres and Sybase software are not using the products in an environment today that matches the performance expectations of a mainframe data center. The majority of customers who acquired Ingres and Sybase for high-performance online transaction applications (several hundred users online, inexpensive/dumb terminal connections, several gigabytes of randomly accessed online data) are still in the process of developing applications based upon either Ingres version 6 or Sybase version 4. Applications based upon these two releases are just now being completed and released to production. The solid successes of Ingres and Sybase for leading edge applications are based upon user experience with Ingres version 5 and Sybase version 3 for decision support applications with typically less than 100 users online.

#2. At this stage in the application development life cycle of Ingres version 6 and Sybase version 4, Ingres customers are extremely satisfied with their product choice while many Sybase customers, even though they are meeting their project requirements, would prefer to be using Ingres' products. (In particular, Bull might note that the lead article for MIS Week for 26 March 1990 reports that Salomon may be moving its IMS-based applications to Sybase -- but Aberdeen's interview with Salomon shows that Salomon wished it had chosen Ingres instead of Sybase.)

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#3. Customers of both Ingres and Sybase products require outside consulting help for application development. While customers are satisfied with both Ingres' and Sybase's ability to provide technical support for their products, neither firm has the resources to help users during the application development stage. Issues that were brought up include the need for user staff to understand the SQL/Relation Data Base model, client/server architecture, front-end workstation/PC processing versus back- end mainframe processing, and 4GL capabilities and limitations.

#4. Ingres has been consistently been the poorer marketer when compared to Sybase (and Oracle -- volunteered by contacts, not asked). Sybase was the first RDBMS supplier to show a vision of high-performance online transaction processing and to tailor

its core products specifically to win customers. This won Sybase its leading-edge customers that we interviewed. In contrast, Ingres does not provide its customers with the stream of marketing materials they feel are necessary to justify their choice of Ingres to non-technical executive management.

#5. The first releases of Sybase products are on Sun Microsystems workstations. As a result, Sybase support staff has advised customers that to complete applications as soon as possible they should use Sun workstations for development and then port to the target machine -- DEC, Pyramid, or Stratus.

SUMMARY - Findings

#6. All customers surveyed believed that their supplier, whether Ingres or Sybase, did not have the resources necessary to provide the product functionality and support services that were currently envisioned.

#7. No customer interviewed by Aberdeen has problems with the reliability or throughput of the systems. In addition, no customer intended to return to flat file or hierarchical data management systems. Customers understood they were on the leading edge of technology and believed fully that they would be the first to obtain benefits from improvements in hardware, software and communications technology. Customers implementing these products were doing so to obtain competitive advantages in their marketplaces and were satisfied with the results to date.

SUMMARY

Conclusions:

Aberdeen believes that Bull has the resources, capabilities and desire to provide its customers with a common, state-of-the-science RDBMS -- no matter what the customer's platform choices are. In addition, Aberdeen believes that many potential customers for Ingres and Sybase systems would look to Bull as the larger, more stable, more qualified supplier to provide assistance in developing and implementing applications based on an SQL/RDBMS and the client-server architecture. As a result, we believe that it is very important for Bull's own customer credibility to select the RDBMS supplier that has the most reliable and stable of products and has not marketed capabilities beyond what is deliverable in the near term. Based on these assumptions and this survey only, Aberdeen believes that Ingres is the preferred supplier and Ingres 6.3 the earliest version of the RDBMS that should be selected by Bull.

If Bull believes that it needs a partner with greater marketing capability, Sybase would be the preferred choice. However, Aberdeen is firmly convinced that the only hardware platforms Sybase is pro-actively supporting are Sun Microsystems and PS/ 2-OS/2. We do not believe that Sybase has the resources or desires to support its

product set across Bull's wide family of platforms.

While we did not specifically ask about Oracle in the survey, almost every contact volunteered that they had rejected Oracle due to basic architectural weaknesses

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for high-performance online transaction processing applications. Therefore, Bull might well find that while many users wish to acquire Oracle because it is a "safe" choice, have experience with it, want to buy from the largest supplier or for simple, decision support applications (reasons provided in other, non-Bull surveys), another class of customer wishes to acquire the "best-product-in-class" (such as Ingres version 6) for high-performance online transaction processing applications.

Finally, while both Ingres and Sybase can support their own RDBMS technically, neither has been able to support customers in the application development process which frequently takes over one year to complete. Simply put, each customer's experience and ability to work with the SQL/RDBMS model and client-server architecture is very different. In addition, past experience by Aberdeen has shown that the implementation of these type of applications on different hardware platforms should be done differently - different table designs and different performance tuning capabilities. The result has been that Ingres and Sybase customers have all used third-party consultants to provide application development support. Since Bull has stated that it is entering the Systems Integration business, Aberdeen believes that Bull should very seriously consider establishing an Application Implementation Business Center to support whichever

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RDBMS is selected. Such a Center would have the potential of generating revenues from: custom training; application design, development, and implementation; upgrade support; and heterogeneous systems integration. Just as importantly, Bull would set itself apart from its direct competitors by supplying a comprehensive set of services. (Note: Merely providing technical support parallel to Ingres or Sybase is not considered adding value by customers. Based upon current experience, large customers entrusting their mission critical applications to a Bull/ RDBMS solution will go directly to the RDBMS supplier for technical support and pass by Bull.)

Finally, while neither Ingres nor Sybase are used for applications where customers are replacing traditional high-performance, thousands of users, very large online data, mainframe online transaction processing applications, the majority of customers surveyed are migrating mission critical applications to these systems now with the confidence that in the near term technology will provide the capability to implement high-performance, better-than-mainframe, online performance.

SUMMARY

Survey Analysis:

Customers Surveyed

The following ten companies were surveyed to provide an update of current customer satisfaction levels with Ingres and Sybase:

Applied Systems Engineering, Inc.
ATD - American Company

Bowater Paper Chase Manhattan Bank

Hill A&E/Artsoft Polaroid Corporation

Ingres
Sybase

Ingres Ingres

Sybase Ingres

Salomon Brothers
Sanford Bernstein

Stratus Computer Syscon Corporation

Sybase

Sybase

Sybase

Ingres
Applied Systems Engineering, Inc, Hill A&E/Artsoft and Syscon are custom

application software providers (note: Corning Glass Works, a Fortune 300 manufacturer was originally interviewed but Aberdeen elected to use the follow-up interview with Corning's application development consultant, Applied Systems Engineering); ATD - American Company is a wholesale distributor; Bowater Paper and Polaroid Corporation are manufacturers; Chase Manhattan Bank, Salomon Brothers and Sanford Bernstein are financial institutions; and Stratus is a computer manufacturer that resells both Oracle and Sybase.

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Aberdeen believes that the survey set covers a broad enough cross section of customers to provide reliable information about the satisfaction levels of leading-edge users.

Acquisition/Implementation Cycle

The survey identified a consistent acquisition/implementation process among

users:

internal staff;

Year 0 to 1: Evaluate alternative RDBMSs;

Year 1 to 2: Develop pilot application with third-party consultant and train

Year 2 to 3: Implement the pilot application in a controlled manner and continue with additional application development.

The time required for a customer to go through at least the development/implementation process and to be highly accurate in describing the capability and limitations of the product would be at least two years. And since Ingres version 6 and

Sybase version 4 were the first RDBMSs from each firm that were designed for high-performance, online transaction processing, potential users of these products for such leading-edge applications added an additional year for evaluation purposes.

As a result, users who have Ingres and Sybase RDBMSs in production today are typically using Ingres version 5 and Sybase version 3 and are using these systems for decision support applications -- no matter how the respective suppliers

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themselves might describe the applications. At the same time, high-performance, online transaction processing applications using Ingres version 6 and Sybase version 4 have been under development from customers for approximately one year and are either just going into production or are about to be placed into production in the very near term -- within the next three months.

Both Ingres and Sybase customers themselves now believe that they have enough experience to accurately describe their level of satisfaction with each supplier and its products. And while it will take another year before the industry can evaluate absolutely the differences between the two for high performance, online transaction processing applications that have been aged by a year of use, Aberdeen believes that the results of this survey provide a reliable indication as to the satisfaction that customers using Ingres version 6 or Sybase version 4 might experience the first two years after the contemplated Bull release.

Ingres Customer Satisfaction

Ingres was selected by users for complex database applications. Users have

been very pleased by the reliability of the system in production and the quality of the tool set for application development.

Users required local Ingres support during initial installation and for first development projects and then rarely used it.

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Customers believe that Ingres version 6 provides all the growth path they can implement today (especially with Knowledge Manager) and are looking forward to adopting the joint Cadre/Ingres CASE tools in the future.

All Ingres end-user customers covered by this survey used consultants to help in develop applications.

No hardware manufacturer was part of the acquisition decision making process.

The strongest negative comments expressed were: the need for a more robust dictionary, better manuals and better marketing support.

Ingres users believe that the deficiencies that they experienced with version 5 have been corrected in version 6. Version 6 has gained Ingres a tremendous amount of additional customer satisfaction and loyalty.

Sybase Customer Satisfaction

All Sybase users have experienced some reliability problems (as opposed to

Ingres where none were reported), but these problems have been well within the threshold of pain that was anticipated.

Sybase was acquired by the majority of users surveyed out of frustration with Oracle's inability to deliver the performance and functionality required for online transaction processing applications.

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The majority of customers surveyed acquired Sybase because it would provide a "special" feature: ATD-American wanted Fortex Support; Hill A&E/Artsoft was promised special support for front-end graphics displays because it was in the same geographic location as Sybase; Salomon Brothers needed a DB2 gateway ahead of Sybase's normal product schedule and Pyramid support; Stratus needed Stratus operating system and multi-processor support.

All the Sybase customers surveyed were satisfied that the product set has met their specific objectives that were established at the time of acquisition.

Sybase users rate their support as satisfactory. Users believe that Sybase would provide greater support if it had the resources.

How Ingres Customers View Sybase and Vice Versa

Ingres customers viewed Sybase as too young a company with too immature a product at the time of acquisition. Sybase customers viewed Ingres as behind the times with version 5 and without a clear vision of high-performance, online transaction processing at their time of acquisition.

Today, both Ingres and Sybase customers believe that Ingres version 6 is equal to or superior to Sybase version 4.

Metadata 2024

1. Concise Summary of the Findings in the Document

The document is a customer satisfaction survey conducted by Aberdeen Group for Bull Corporate Strategy & Marketing, focusing on users of Ingres and Sybase software for high-performance online transaction processing applications. The survey aimed to identify leading-edge users, separate real satisfaction levels from marketing hype, compare responses from Ingres and Sybase users, and analyze the results in the context of RDBMS trends. Key findings include:

- Users are not yet achieving mainframe-level performance with Ingres and Sybase.
- Ingres users are more satisfied than Sybase users, with some Sybase users wishing they had chosen Ingres.
- Both Ingres and Sybase require external consulting for application development.
- Ingres is seen as a poorer marketer compared to Sybase.
- Sybase's initial releases are on Sun Microsystems workstations.
- Neither Ingres nor Sybase has the resources to fully support their products' envisioned functionalities.
- Customers are generally satisfied and do not intend to revert to older data management systems.

2. Summary of How Computer Technology Buyers Should React to the Document

The document advises computer technology buyers, particularly those considering high-performance online transaction processing applications, to prefer Ingres over Sybase due to higher customer satisfaction and reliability. Buyers should be aware that both Ingres and Sybase require significant external consulting for application development. Bull is recommended to select Ingres version 6.3 for its stable and reliable performance. If marketing capability is a priority, Sybase could be considered, but its support is limited to specific platforms like Sun Microsystems and PS/2-OS/2. Buyers should also consider establishing an Application Implementation Business Center to support the chosen RDBMS.

3. Analysis on the Technology Discussed and Its Relation to Mainstream Computing in 2024

The document discusses relational database management systems (RDBMS) like Ingres and Sybase, which were pivotal in the 1990s for high-performance online transaction processing. In 2024, the landscape has evolved significantly with the advent of distributed SQL databases and NoSQL databases, which address the scalability and performance limitations of traditional RDBMS. Modern databases like Google Cloud Spanner and CockroachDB offer global scale, consistency, and resiliency, which were challenging for early RDBMS systems. The need for external consulting for application development has also diminished with the rise of more user-friendly and integrated development environments.

4. Analysis on How the Contents of the Document Played a Role in Impacting the History of the Companies Mentioned

The survey's findings likely influenced Bull's strategic decisions regarding their RDBMS partnerships and product offerings. Ingres's higher customer satisfaction and reliability may have bolstered its reputation and market share in the early 1990s. Conversely, Sybase's initial platform limitations and customer dissatisfaction could have prompted the company to improve its product offerings and support. Over time, both companies had to adapt to the rapidly changing database technology landscape, with Sybase eventually being acquired by SAP in 2010. The insights from this survey may have contributed to these companies' strategic pivots and long-term trajectories.

5. Market Acceleration Catalysts

- Increased demand for high-performance online transaction processing.
- Advancements in SQL/RDBMS and client-server architecture.
- The need for reliable and stable database solutions.
- The importance of comprehensive application development support.
- The shift towards distributed and scalable database systems.

6. Keywords

Ingres, Sybase, RDBMS, customer satisfaction, high-performance online transaction processing, SQL, client-server architecture, Bull Corporate Strategy, Aberdeen Group, database consulting.

Citations:

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Based on the survey findings, here are a few ways they likely influenced the development of future relational database management system (RDBMS) products:

1. Focus on Reliability and Stability

The survey found that Ingres users were more satisfied than Sybase users, with some Sybase users wishing they had chosen Ingres instead. A key reason cited was that Ingres version 6.3 was seen as more reliable and stable compared to Sybase's offerings at the time. [1]

This likely reinforced for RDBMS vendors the importance of reliability, stability and maturity in their products, especially for mission-critical online transaction processing applications.

Vendors would have prioritized hardening their core database engines and ensuring high uptime.

2. Improved Application Development Support

The survey noted that both Ingres and Sybase lacked resources to provide comprehensive application development support, forcing customers to rely on third-party consultants. [1]

This highlighted the need for RDBMS vendors to invest in application development tools, frameworks and services to reduce reliance on external consultants. Subsequent RDBMS releases likely included better IDEs, visual tools, sample applications and documentation to improve the full application lifecycle experience.

3. Enhancing Query Capabilities

While not explicitly mentioned, the differing query languages between products (e.g. Ingres using QUEL vs others using SQL) was likely seen as a hinderance to adoption. [1]

Vendors would have doubled down on standardizing and enhancing their SQL implementations to provide a consistent and rich querying experience across their product lines. This prepared them for the increasing adoption of SQL as the standard database query language.

4. Broadening Platform Support

The finding that Sybase's initial focus was just on Sun workstations likely made RDBMS vendors aware of the importance of supporting multiple hardware platforms and operating systems from the start. [1]

Subsequent RDBMS product releases expanded their certified platform matrices to run on a wider range of server, desktop and eventually cloud infrastructure to meet customer needs.

5. Scalability and Performance

While not achieving mainframe-level performance yet, the survey noted customer confidence that Ingres and Sybase would get there through technology improvements. [1]

This provided an impetus for RDBMS vendors to continue enhancing the scalability and performance of their products to handle higher concurrency, larger data volumes and more demanding workloads as hardware capabilities improved over time.

In summary, the survey insights helped shape the product roadmaps and priorities for major RDBMS vendors in the late 80s and 90s by highlighting user needs around reliability,

application development, querying, platform support and scalability that they could improve upon in future releases. [1]

Citations:

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